

I Remember, I Remember



POEM TEXT

1 I remember, I remember,
2 The house where I was born,
3 The little window where the sun
4 Came peeping in at morn;
5 He never came a wink too soon,
6 Nor brought too long a day,
7 But now, I often wish the night
8 Had borne my breath away!

9 I remember, I remember,
10 The roses, red and white,
11 The vi'lets, and the lily-cups,
12 Those flowers made of light!
13 The lilacs where the robin built,
14 And where my brother set
15 The laburnum on his birthday,—
16 The tree is living yet!

17 I remember, I remember,
18 Where I was used to swing,
19 And thought the air must rush as fresh
20 To swallows on the wing;
21 My spirit flew in feathers then,
22 That is so heavy now,
23 And summer pools could hardly cool
24 The fever on my brow!

25 I remember, I remember,
26 The fir trees dark and high;
27 I used to think their slender tops
28 Were close against the sky:
29 It was a childish ignorance,
30 But now 'tis little joy
31 To know I'm farther off from heav'n
32 Than when I was a boy.

But these days, I often wish I'd died during the night!

I remember the red and white roses, the violets, and the lilies—flowers that seemed to be made of light. I remember the lilac bush where the robins nested, and the place where my brother planted the laburnum tree on his birthday; it's still growing today!

I remember where I used to play on the swing; I felt sure that the air rushing past me must feel just as fresh to swooping swallows. My soul seemed to be a bird then, but now it's weighed down—and even a summer swim couldn't cool my feverish forehead!

I remember the tall fir trees; I used to believe their tops nearly touched the sky. That was just childish foolishness. But now that I'm an adult, it doesn't give me much pleasure to know that heaven is farther away than I believed it was when I was little.



THEMES



NOSTALGIA FOR THE JOY OF CHILDHOOD

The speaker of “I Remember, I Remember” looks back with mingled love and pain at the days of his childhood. When he was a child, he remembers, he felt in tune with the world around him, loved the beauty of nature, and took delight in every day. Adulthood, alas, doesn't feel like that at all. To a sad or suffering adult, this poem suggests, the innocent freedom of childhood can look like a lost paradise; growing up seems to mean all loss and little reward.

In this speaker's memory, childhood might as well have been an eternal summer holiday. The “roses,” “vi'lets” (violets), and “lily-cups” (lilies) were always in bloom; the days always felt just the right length; and riding a swing, the speaker felt as if his “spirit flew in feathers” like a swallow. He delighted in the natural world around him and greeted every day with joy. (The speaker is idealizing his youth here: it couldn't *always* have been a blissful summer day when he was a boy, after all. Nonetheless, he's capturing something important about a kind of joy he only felt as a child.)

As an adult, by contrast, the speaker's soul feels anything but feather-light. He's “heavy” with worries, there's a “fever on [his] brow,” and he often wishes that he'd just die in the night so he wouldn't have to face the morning. Looking back on his youth, he feels a melancholy, bittersweet nostalgia for a time when he was joyfully in tune with the world around him and unburdened by cares. For this speaker, being a child meant living a life of freedom, exhilaration, and easy joy—and adulthood feels like



SUMMARY

I remember the house I was born in, with the little window where the morning sun peeked in. Back then, the sun never seemed to rise too early, and the day never seemed too long.

getting kicked out of paradise.

Where this theme appears in the poem:

- Lines 1-32



CHILDREN'S CONNECTION TO NATURE

This poem takes a very capital-R Romantic view of childhood, suggesting that children are closely in tune with nature—and thus closely in tune with the divine. Like Thomas Hood's contemporary [William Wordsworth](#), this poem's speaker feels that children, through their connection to the natural world, can reach toward "heav'n" in a way that adults can't.

The speaker remembers that, in his boyhood, he once believed that the "fir trees" around his childhood home were "close against the sky": that is, that they almost touched the sky. As an adult, he knows that this was just "childish ignorance." But he also wishes that he could still be so blissfully ignorant. Now that he knows that the sky isn't just a blue roof, so close you can almost touch it, he feels "farther off from heav'n" both literally and [figuratively](#). To a child, these words suggest, heaven itself seems within arm's reach.

Part of children's closeness to heaven, in this speaker's view, comes from their instinctive delight in nature. When he was a boy, the speaker remembers, he saw the sun as a friend, relished the intense colors of the flowers, and felt that he must know how the swallows feel when he rode on his swing. In fact, almost all of his memories of childhood have to do with reveling in the beauty of the natural world. Such an easy relish of nature, the poem suggests, allows children to feel that this world might indeed be pretty close to "heav'n."

Where this theme appears in the poem:

- Lines 3-6
- Lines 9-16
- Lines 17-24
- Lines 25-32



LINE-BY-LINE ANALYSIS

LINES 1-8

*I remember, I remember,
The house where I was born,
The little window where the sun
Came peeping in at morn;
He never came a wink too soon,
Nor brought too long a day,
But now, I often wish the night
Had borne my breath away!*

The poem begins with a fond reminiscence of the speaker's childhood home: "I remember, I remember, / The house where I was born" he begins, his rhythmic [epizeuxis](#) working like a spell to carry him into his memories.

In particular, he remembers the mornings, when the sun came "peeping in" his "little window" to wake him up. Back then, he suggests, he felt like the sun was a friend. He [personifies](#) the sun as he describes its thoughtfulness: "He never came a wink too soon, / Nor brought too long a day." The young speaker and his pal the sun were perfectly in agreement about life, it seems. Under this sun's friendly guidance, mornings were always welcome, and days never dragged out too long.

The little speaker and the early sun might have been in tune in a different way, too: both were morning creatures, [symbolically](#) speaking. The speaker is remembering a time in the morning of his life, when he wasn't just friendly with the morning sun but also *like* the morning sun, at the very beginning of his life's journey.

Already, readers might get the sense that this lovely relationship with the sun—and thus, with the passing of time—hasn't lasted into the speaker's adulthood. Even by raising the idea that the sun *could* "bring too long a day," the speaker implies that, since then, he's run into days that feel far too long.

In fact, some of the speaker's days might feel almost unendurable. He closes this stanza with an abrupt change of tone, confiding that, these days, he often wishes that "the night / Had borne my breath away!" He sometimes wishes, in other words, that he might just die in the night and not have to endure yet another sunrise and yet another day. (The blunt /b/ [alliteration](#) of "borne my breath away" adds extra punch to this painful idea.) Things have changed since childhood, then. This sharp, sad [juxtaposition](#) between youthful mornings of happiness and adult nights of misery will lie at the heart of this poem.

The speaker will deliver his sad reflections in octaves (eight-line stanzas) written in a variation on [common meter](#):

- In common meter, lines of iambic tetrameter (lines of four [iamb](#)s, metrical feet with a da-DUM rhythm, as in "He nev- | er came | a wink | too soon") alternate with lines of iambic trimeter (lines of three iamb's, as in "The house | where I | was born").
- This poem's stanzas *almost* follow that rhythm. But the echoing first line—"I remember, I remember"—falls into a different, dreamier pattern, with just two strong stresses: "I remember, I remember."
- That quiet opening line fittingly stands apart from the speaker's descriptions of his childhood—just as he must stand apart from his memories, unable to return to his youthful happiness.

LINES 9-16

*I remember, I remember,
The roses, red and white,
The vi'lets, and the lily-cups,
Those flowers made of light!
The lilacs where the robin built,
And where my brother set
The laburnum on his birthday,—
The tree is living yet!*

The second stanza begins with the same words the first started with: “I remember, I remember.” This invocation of memory has become a [refrain](#), an echo that keeps the idea of memory right in front of the reader’s eyes. Through his [repetition](#) of these words, the speaker calls up his memories *and* keeps them at a distance. He isn’t just sinking into fond thoughts of his past, he’s describing how helplessly he’s stuck gazing back at them, unable to return to those happier days.

Now, he remembers the garden around his childhood home, a landscape overflowing with summer flowers: “roses, red and white,” “lily-cups,” “lilacs,” “vi’lets.” (Note that Hood contracts the word “violets” there so it will fit into his meter; the world used to be pronounced with three syllables, *VI-o-lets*.)

These flowers, the speaker cries, were “made of light”—a [metaphor](#) that suggests he saw an ethereal, perhaps heavenly beauty in his earthly garden. Here, Hood’s speaker seems to agree with the big Romantic thinkers of his era: children, he hints, [see nature differently than adults do](#), perceiving the divine in the living, growing world. The speaker remembers that his family had a lovely garden, yes, but more than that, he remembers that he once saw this garden with different eyes.

The speaker also remembers gentler, cozier sights, like robins’ nests in the lilac trees and the “laburnum” (a kind of ornamental tree) that his brother planted “on his birthday.” Here, again, the present intrudes on the past: “The tree is living yet,” the speaker says, a line that suggests he has returned to this garden and seen the tree his brother planted long ago, still growing.

That idea is hopeful, perhaps; the garden isn’t dead or gone, and nor is the speaker, and nor (readers can hope) is his brother. The laburnum lives on, and so do they. But in the light of the speaker’s earlier confession that he sometimes wishes he wouldn’t wake up in the morning, the continued presence of the laburnum in the garden might be more a painful reminder that his life isn’t what it used to be than a comforting reminder of continuity.

LINES 17-24

*I remember, I remember,
Where I was used to swing,
And thought the air must rush as fresh
To swallows on the wing;
My spirit flew in feathers then,*

*That is so heavy now,
And summer pools could hardly cool
The fever on my brow!*

Once more beginning with his spell-like [refrain](#)—“I remember, I remember”—the speaker now turns to his childhood memories of riding a swing in his garden. As he swung, he recalls, he used to think that “the air must rush as fresh / To swallows on the wing”: that swooping swallows must take the same kind of delight in the rushing air that he did. (The poem’s [consonance](#) here helps readers to share in that delight: the /sh/ sounds of “rush” and “fresh” capture that delicious swing-breeze.)

The speaker again reveals how closely his little self was attuned to nature. “My spirit flew in feathers then,” he says, a [metaphor](#) that suggests he felt a deep kinship with the swallows in their exhilarating flight. That feathered lightness, like everything else, has changed. Now, his soul is “heavy,” weighed to the earth by his worries and sorrows.

Even if he returned to the same landscape he grew up in, it couldn’t lift his heavy spirits; if he were to dunk himself in one of the “summer pools” where he used to swim, he says, its waters couldn’t “cool / The fever on [his] brow.” Whether that fever is a metaphorical fever of emotion or a literal fever (a kind of illness with which the always sickly Thomas Hood was all too familiar), the speaker feels helpless before it.

At this point, readers might begin to wonder about what nostalgia does to the speaker’s memories. When he remembers childhood, he seems to remember a time of eternal warmth and light: all the flowers and animals he mentions appear, in England, only in the summer. As in the speaker’s relationship with the sun, there’s a [symbolic](#) significance here. The speaker is looking back on the metaphorical summer of his life; no wonder that all he sees are glowing flowers and swooping swallows. Perhaps this vision of an eternal summer garden even suggests Eden (or, better yet, [Eden before Eve turned up](#)). This is a vision of a completely innocent paradise—a paradise lost.

This vision of childhood is obviously an idealized one. The speaker makes no mention of getting stomach bugs or having to trudge off to school. His memories of childhood aren’t precisely a recounting of his life story; instead, he’s remembering a way he often *felt* in childhood, and, the poem implies, could only feel in childhood.

LINES 25-32

*I remember, I remember,
The fir trees dark and high;
I used to think their slender tops
Were close against the sky:
It was a childish ignorance,
But now 'tis little joy
To know I'm farther off from heav'n
Than when I was a boy.*

With one last repetition of his [refrain](#), the speaker turns to a final memory: an impression of the “fir trees” around his childhood home. “Dark and high,” these trees feel grander than the flowers and birds the speaker has described so far. And if they’re fir trees, they’re unlike those flowers and birds in another important way: they’re evergreen. Unlike roses, violets, and swallows, they flourish all year round. [Symbolically](#), they suggest eternity.

The speaker recalls these trees with awe. “I used to think their slender tops / Were close against the sky,” he says: in other words, he used to think that the trees were so tall they actually touched the sky, holding the heavens up like columns supporting a roof. As an adult, he knows that this was just “childish ignorance.” But it’s a kind of childish ignorance he misses and laments. It’s “little joy,” he says, no comfort at all, to be less ignorant now: it only means he’s “farther off from heav’n” than he was when he was a boy.

In this context, those words take on a double meaning. There’s a rueful little laugh here: there’s something childishly sweet about the idea that the heavens might be so close to earth, something no adult could believe. But more importantly, the speaker also feels further from heaven in the sense that he can no longer perceive the world as a heavenly place. When he was a boy, the flowers were made of light and his soul was a swallow: nature was paradise. Now that he’s an adult, the world is a crueler place, and heaven—if it’s accessible at all—seems far, far away.

The image of sky-touching evergreen trees might hint at something consolingly eternal: a connection to the heavens that doesn’t have to end when childhood does. But such consolation isn’t within this melancholy speaker’s reach right now. All he can do is “remember” the long-ago time when he felt that he was part of a kindly summer world.

he’s in a very different season of life now: adulthood, by extension, must mean autumn and winter, chilly times of loss.

Where this symbol appears in the poem:

- **Lines 3-4:** “the sun / Came peeping in at morn;”
- **Lines 10-13:** “The roses, red and white, / The vi’lets, and the lily-cups, / Those flowers made of light! / The lilacs where the robin built,”
- **Line 20:** “swallows on the wing”
- **Line 23:** “summer pools”



THE FIR TREES

Most of the plants that the speaker describes in this poem only blossom in the warm months: roses, violets, lilacs, and lilies are all summer flowers. At the end of the poem, however, he remembers the “fir trees” that grew around his home. When the speaker was little, he recalls, he thought that the fir trees might reach all the way up to “heav’n.” This image of trees brushing up against the sky represents how close the speaker felt to heaven as a child—how heavenly childhood itself was in the speaker’s young eyes. Now, however, the speaker sees this idea as only “childish ignorance.” The loss of this belief about the fir trees reflects the loss of that childhood ignorance, but also the loss of blissful childhood innocence. As an adult, he feels “farther off” from heaven than he did as a child.

At the same time, those evergreen trees, which stay just the same year-round, might [symbolically](#) suggest eternity, subtly counterbalancing the poem’s nostalgic sadness. By introducing an image of trees that traditionally symbolize eternal life—and associating those trees with heaven—the poem hints that nature might still offer the speaker hope for heavenly consolation, even if the summer of his life is lost.

Where this symbol appears in the poem:

- **Lines 25-28:** “I remember, I remember, / The fir trees dark and high; / I used to think their slender tops / Were close against the sky:”



SYMBOLS



SUMMER

The sights and sounds of summer [symbolize](#) childhood and its joys. When the speaker looks back on his youth, he seems to feel as if he never lived in any month but mid-June. The sun always shone bright; the roses, lilies, and violets were always in bloom; the swallows were always on the wing. What’s more, the speaker felt attuned to these natural beauties. He and the sun always seemed to agree about when was the right time for the day to begin and end, and the swallows and his “spirit” alike “flew in feathers.”

Childhood was, in other words, the happy summer of the speaker’s life, a time when just to be alive felt like having the best imaginable sunny day out in the garden. By connecting his childhood so insistently to the summer, the speaker implies that



POETIC DEVICES

REPETITION

The poem’s [repetitions](#) bring its themes of nostalgia and memory to center stage, starting from the very first line: “I remember, I remember.” The [epizeuxis](#) on those words helps to capture what memory feels like: the speaker uses an echoing phrasing to describe an echoing experience. This epizeuxis might also suggest a certain relentlessness in the speaker’s memories. Maybe he isn’t trying to think fondly back on his

childhood so much as he's being helplessly carried back into his memories of those happier days.

That sense of helplessness only gets stronger when this already repetitive phrase becomes a [refrain](#). Every stanza of the poem begins with those same two words, keeping memory always in front of the speaker's (and the reader's) eyes. Remembering childhood, all these repetitions suggest, might be just as painful as it's comforting: the chant-like repetition of "I remember, I remember" hints that the speaker can't look away from thoughts of happier days.

Perhaps these repetitions also invite readers to wonder what the speaker *doesn't* remember. Childhood isn't all one long summer day, after all. The speaker's idealized picture of the past leaves out school, head lice, and going to bed while the sun's still up.

Where Repetition appears in the poem:

- **Line 1:** "I remember, I remember,"
- **Line 9:** "I remember, I remember,"
- **Line 17:** "I remember, I remember,"
- **Line 25:** "I remember, I remember,"

METAPHOR

The speaker's [metaphors](#) suggest that his childhood felt like an enchanted garden, a paradise where all of nature conspired to delight him. (Or at the very least, his *memories* of his childhood feel like an enchanted garden: looking back now, he remembers only the bliss of childhood.)

The magic began every morning when a [personified](#) sun came "peeping in" his window like a buddy eager to wake him up. "He never came a wink too soon," the speaker remembers: this sun was of one mind with the speaker, both of them ready to greet another joyful day at exactly the same time. This personification suggests that the speaker once felt perfectly in tune with the rhythm of the days. The rising sun never warned of a day of suffering then.

And how could it, when the speaker emerged every day into a world of delights? The speaker remembers seeing the roses, lilies, and violets of his childhood garden as "flowers made of light," glowing with ethereal color. This metaphor suggests a heavenly scene, as if the flowers were the perfect, eternal spirit of flower-ness. A "flower made of light" doesn't seem likely to wilt, droop, or fade.

Back then, the speaker felt like part of this glowing natural world. His "spirit rode in feathers then," he remembers: his soul felt as light, free, and exuberant as a "swallow" swooping overhead. This metaphor—and all the speaker's metaphors—connect the speaker's childhood to the sights of the summer. As a little boy, the speaker feels, he could rejoice in a natural world that seemed endlessly beautiful, friendly, and

sunlit; he was as much a part of nature as a little bird. In adulthood, he feels as if he's been cast out of that harmonious paradise.

Where Metaphor appears in the poem:

- **Lines 3-6:** "the sun / Came peeping in at morn; / He never came a wink too soon, / Nor brought too long a day,"
- **Lines 10-12:** "The roses, red and white, / The vi'lets, and the lily-cups, / Those flowers made of light!"
- **Lines 21-22:** "My spirit flew in feathers then, / That is so heavy now,"

JUXTAPOSITION

Each of this poem's stanzas sets up a mournful [juxtaposition](#) between the past and the present. Typically, the speaker starts his stanzas by reflecting on an idealized memory of his childhood, remembering youth as a time when he felt perfectly in tune with the world. He greeted each sunrise with joy, he relished the beauty of flowers and the grandeur of trees, he felt as light and free as a swooping swallow.

But then the other shoe drops: now that he's an adult, the speaker confesses, all that joy and ease have vanished. The speaker never explains what it is about his adult life that makes his soul feel "heavy"—so heavy, in fact, that he sometimes wishes he might be "borne away" by death overnight. But perhaps the mere loss of childhood joy is enough to make life feel like a burden. This poem follows a [Romantic-era tradition](#) in imagining childhood as a time when one is close to "heav'n," more able to see divine beauty in the world than adults are. In particular, it suggests that children get close to heaven through their special affinity with nature. As a little boy, this speaker could feel one with the sparrows and the flowers; as an adult, he can't find his way into that enchanted paradise anymore.

Where Juxtaposition appears in the poem:

- **Lines 5-8:** "He never came a wink too soon, / Nor brought too long a day, / But now, I often wish the night / Had borne my breath away!"
- **Lines 21-24:** "My spirit flew in feathers then, / That is so heavy now, / And summer pools could hardly cool / The fever on my brow!"
- **Lines 25-32:** "I remember, I remember, / The fir trees dark and high; / I used to think their slender tops / Were close against the sky: / It was a childish ignorance, / But now 'tis little joy / To know I'm farther off from heav'n / Than when I was a boy."

ALLITERATION

[Alliteration](#) gives the speaker's voice emphasis and music, highlighting his feelings about his happy past and his sorrowful

present. For instance, consider the moment of high drama in lines 7-8, the end of the first stanza. For most of this stanza, the speaker has been remembering how happily he used to greet the sunrise as a child. As an adult, however, he feels quite differently:

But now, I often wish the night
Had borne my breath away!

These paired /n/ and /b/ sounds make the speaker's abrupt death-wish stand out even more startlingly.

In the next stanza, sweeter sounds accentuate the speaker's description of his childhood home's garden:

The vi'lets, and the lily-cups,
Those flowers made of light!
The lilacs where the robin built,
And where my brother set
The laburnum on his birthday,—
The tree is living yet!

This long chain of gentle, lilting /l/ sounds (deepened by the internal /l/ [consonance](#) of "flowers," "vi'lets," "lily-cups," and "lilacs," as well as the long /i/ [assonance](#) of "vi'lets," "light," "lilacs") makes this garden sound as harmonious as it looks.

And when the speaker describes how his soul once "flew in feathers" like a little bird, his jaunty /f/ alliteration gives his words a fitting lift.

Where Alliteration appears in the poem:

- **Line 8:** "borne," "breath"
- **Line 9:** "remember"
- **Line 10:** "roses, red"
- **Line 11:** "lily-cups"
- **Line 12:** "light"
- **Line 13:** "lilacs"
- **Line 15:** "laburnum"
- **Line 16:** "living"
- **Line 21:** "flew," "feathers"
- **Line 27:** "slender"
- **Line 28:** "sky"

syllables: VI-o-lets.

Lily-cups (Line 11) - That is, the cup-shaped blossoms of the lilies.

Set (Line 14) - Planted.

Laburnum (Line 15) - A kind of ornamental tree.

Where I was used to swing (Line 18) - That is, "where I used to play on a swing."

'Tis (Line 30) - A contraction of "it is."



FORM, METER, & RHYME

FORM

"I Remember, I Remember" is divided into four octaves (or eight-line stanzas), each framing a particular memory of the speaker's childhood home: his bedroom window, the flowers in the garden, the swing, the tall fir trees. Every stanza uses an alternating ABCB DEFE [rhyme scheme](#) that breaks it down into two four-line parts:

- The first section fondly describes the speaker's boyhood joys.
- The second introduces the speaker's adult experience, usually setting up an unhappy [juxtaposition](#): his once birdlike soul is "heavy" now, the mornings he used to greet so happily now begin days that drag out for "too long."

Maybe the poem's most distinctive formal feature is its [refrain](#): the "I remember, I remember" that begins every stanza. Those repeated words feel almost like a spell the speaker recites to bring his happier days back to his mind. Or perhaps they suggest his powerlessness in the face of his memories: he can't *help* but remember those better days now that he's living out his unhappy adulthood.

The rhythm of this refrain cuts across the poem's [meter](#). For the most part, the poem uses a variation on [common meter](#), a meter that uses alternating lines of iambic tetrameter (lines of four [iamb](#)s, metrical feet with a da-DUM rhythm, as in "He nev- | er came | a wink | too soon") and iambic trimeter (lines of three iambs, as in "The house | where I | was born"). This rhythm is indeed common: it turns up in a lot of old ballads and folk songs. But the muttery, dithery, mostly unstressed rhythms of "I remember, I remember" don't quite fit into that pattern.

Perhaps the contrast helps to underscore one of the speaker's feelings: *remembering* the past and being able to *reclaim* the past are very different things. He can't get back into the swing of his childhood joy just through remembering it, much as he longs to.

METER

"I Remember, I Remember" uses a variation on [common meter](#).



VOCABULARY

At morn (Line 4) - In the morning.

Borne (Line 8) - Carried, taken. In saying he wishes "the night / Had borne my breath away," the speaker is saying that he wishes he died in the night.

Vi'lets (Line 11) - A contraction of "violets." Hood specifies this contraction because "violets" was once pronounced with three

In a poem written in common meter, the lines alternate between iambic tetrameter (lines of four [iamb](#)s, metrical feet with a da-DUM rhythm, as in line 5's "He nev- | er came | a wink | too soon") and iambic trimeter (lines of three iambs, as in line 12 "Those flow- | ers made | of light!"). This was a popular form in Hood's era: Hood was one of many writers who followed in the footsteps of writers like [Coleridge](#) and [Wordsworth](#), influential Romantic poets who advocated for a return to the simple forms and language of old [ballads](#) and folk songs.

Here, there are a couple of small differences, though. First off, poems in common meter are usually written in [quatrains](#) (or four-line stanzas); here, the speaker doubles those quatrains up, forming octaves.

Then there's the [refrain](#) that opens every stanza. The rhythm of these echoing words is almost (but not exactly) anapestic dimeter, a line of two [anapests](#). An anapest is a metrical foot with a da-da-DUM rhythm; these anapests each have an extra unstressed syllable clinging to their ends, like this:

I remember, | I remember

Each stanza thus starts with a pulsing, muttery line, like a chant or a spell taking the speaker back into the steady swing of his memories.

RHYME SCHEME

"I Remember, I Remember" follows a simple [rhyme scheme](#) that runs like this:

ABCDEFEE

This pattern breaks each octave (or eight-line stanza) down into two four-line passages, each with the same kind of alternating rhyme pattern. This light, easy interplay of sounds feels simple and nursery-rhyme-ish, suiting the poem's nostalgic tone.

Across the poem, of course, the first A rhyme is always the same: the echoing "remember" of the [refrain](#) forms an identical rhyme that ties the whole work together. The speaker also throws in an emphatic [internal rhyme](#) at the end of the third stanza:

And summer pools could hardly cool
The fever on my brow!

This extra little dash of rhyme adds special intensity to the speaker's dark musings on his unquenchable fever—an image that might be read [metaphorically](#) as a vision of adult cares and worries, but also literally as Thomas Hood's all-too-real account of dealing with persistent illnesses (which would kill him at the age of only 45).



SPEAKER

The speaker is a voice for Thomas Hood himself. Hood suffered from bad health for much of his short life; he would die at the age of 45 after years of sickness. The "fever" on the speaker's brow isn't just a [metaphorical](#) fever of worry or unhappiness, then, but a very real ailment.

However, readers don't need to know Hood's history to understand this speaker's character. This nostalgic man looks back on the happy days of his youth with deep sorrow, understanding his childhood as a lost paradise. In his fond memories, every day of boyhood was bliss: the flowers seemed to be "made of light," the sun never "brought too long a day," and to ride on a swing was to feel as free and light as "swallows on the wing."

Adulthood feels very different. Though the speaker never explains exactly why his life feels so painfully changed now, he darkly hints that all is the opposite of what it once was: his once birdlike spirit is "heavy now," and the joys of summer can no longer soothe him. Perhaps, the poem suggests, a loss of wholehearted childhood delight is just part of growing up, whether or not one is enduring particular sufferings.



SETTING

This poem seems to take place almost entirely in the speaker's memories of his childhood home. He thinks back fondly on the "house where [he] was born," a place that (to his nostalgic mind) seemed like an earthly paradise. In the speaker's memory of childhood, it always seems to be high summer: the roses, violets, and lilies are in bloom; the swallows are swooping; the cheery sun comes "peeping in" the speaker's window every morning.

The speaker's vision of these bright, happy days of boyhood freedom is clearly rose-tinted. He doesn't recall, say, trudging to school in a rainstorm or getting stuck in bed with the mumps. His vision of his childhood is both romantic and capital-R Romantic: [like Hood's contemporary William Wordsworth](#), this speaker treats childhood as a time when you're closer to heaven than you can ever be as an adult.

Alas, life has changed for the speaker now. Though the speaker never reveals much about his adult circumstances, readers can gather that life feels very far from his childhood paradise these days. Adult cares and worries make his soul heavy. And even though the laburnum tree his brother planted is "living yet"—a line that suggests the speaker can still visit his childhood home if he likes—the old *feeling* of the place is lost forever.



CONTEXT

LITERARY CONTEXT

Thomas Hood (1799-1845) was a British poet, journalist, and humorist. Born and raised in London, he would become one of the city's important literary men, a champion and friend of some of the most notable writers of English Romanticism. In his role as a sub-editor of *The London Magazine*, he traveled in the same circles as [John Keats](#), [John Clare](#), [Charles Lamb](#), and [Samuel Taylor Coleridge](#).

In this poem, Hood shows his own Romantic stripes. His vision of childhood as a time when people are closer to heaven than they could ever be as adults reveals the influence of William Wordsworth (one of the granddaddies of English Romanticism), who [famously wrote](#) that children see the natural world with the "glory and the freshness of a dream"—a power of seeing that fades away as they grow up.

Other works of Hood's are also rooted in 19th-century concerns about the lives of the working poor. His famous "[Song of the Shirt](#)" tells the story of a seamstress working her life away "in poverty, hunger, and dirt," without "one short hour" for leisure, or even for tears of grief over her predicament. This poem—which made a splash, getting republished and discussed all over Europe—was part of a rising 19th-century tide of radical literature, in which writers like [Percy Shelley](#), [Blake](#), and [Dickens](#) railed against economic and political injustice (all in their different ways).

Though one wouldn't know it from "I Remember, I Remember" or "Song of the Shirt," Hood also loved humor and light verse. Over the course of his short life, he would edit several journals of comic writing, including *Hood's Monthly Magazine and Comic Miscellany*, *The Gem*, and the *Comic Annual*.

Next to "Song of the Shirt," "I Remember, I Remember" is perhaps Hood's most famous poem, and recent writers like [Philip Larkin](#) and [Mary Ruefle](#) have responded to it in verse and prose.

HISTORICAL CONTEXT

This nostalgic poem draws on Thomas Hood's own experiences. While Hood was born right in the middle of London on Poultry (a central street in the oldest part of town), his family moved to Islington when he was small. Islington is now unequivocally urban, swallowed up by the expanding city. But when Hood was writing, it was still a leafy suburb surrounded by fields. It's this early home that Hood's speaker thinks of so wistfully here.

The speaker's adult sorrows, sadly, are also Hood's own. Hood always had troubles with his health, and the speaker's mention

of the "fever on [his] brow" is an all-too-real evocation of Hood's sufferings. He wrote this poem in 1826, when he was only 27, but he was already suffering from the beginnings of the ailments that would eventually kill him.

Hood was one of many young poets of this era whose career was cut tragically short. While he outlived [Keats](#) (who died of tuberculosis at 25), [Percy Shelley](#) (who drowned at 29), and [Byron](#) (who died of a fever at 36), he nonetheless joined an unhappy Romantic literary tradition when he died at 45.



MORE RESOURCES

EXTERNAL RESOURCES

- [A Contemporary's Memory of Hood](#) — Read a reflection on Hood by his acquaintance S. C. Hall. (<https://www.victorianweb.org/authors/hood/hallbio.html>)
- [The Comic Annual](#) — Take a look at the text of an edition of Hood's *Comic Annual* for a glimpse of the poet's influential role as a humorist and editor. (https://minorvictorianwriters.org.uk/hood/b_comic_annual.htm)
- [A Brief Biography](#) — Read an overview of Hood's life and work. (<https://poets.org/poet/thomas-hood>)
- [The Poem Aloud](#) — Listen to a reading of the poem. (<https://youtu.be/2nqCfuLnSiM?si=Hd185L4bv07caGKt>)
- [Portraits of Hood](#) — See some portraits of Hood made not long before his untimely death. (<https://www.npg.org.uk/collections/search/person/mp128010/thomas-hood>)

LITCHARTS ON OTHER THOMAS HOOD POEMS

- [The Song of the Shirt](#)



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